Rahul Gandhi further asked us what the central issues in the Indian freedom movement were. We said there were two basic or critical ideas that the nationalist leaders and workers carried to the people of India. One, that we needed to get the British to leave, because they were exploiting India and there was a drain of wealth from India to Britain; and two, that we would replace British rule with a democratic system—prajatantra or lokatantra—and not a monarchy, or a feudal or authoritarian system of government. Also, we added, they convinced people that British rule was not invincible—it could be defeated. While the early nationalists or moderates were the ones who developed the basic structure of the ideology of colonial exploitation leading to the poverty of the peasant, it was in the Gandhian phase that it was carried to the people, including in the rural areas, and the so-called invincibility of British rule, 'on which the sun never set', was openly challenged. We talked about how Jawaharlal Nehru described the impact of the coming of Gandhi ji on the Indian scene in *The Discovery of India* as making people give up their fear of authorities. (The quotation at the beginning of the chapter refers to this.)

Rahul Gandhi then told us a story about how on one occasion in the course of the Yatra, he reached out and touched two poor children, only to be later told by a leader that he should not have done that because they were dirty. He said that before Independence, the Congress was dependent on the producing classes and not on the rich, whereas now it was dependent on contractors and businessmen. We agreed with him about the days of the freedom struggle and recounted how the British government had actually conducted an inquiry into the role of what they called the 'Gandhian moneybags' in the movement and come to the conclusion that the Congress was not dependent on them, but relied on membership fees and mostly unpaid volunteer work and support of local communities.

He was curious to know more about Sardar Patel, Dr Ambedkar and Gandhi ji, and asked questions about their views on different issues. We also discussed what we could learn from the national movement about how to involve the people, not only by talking to them and listening to them, as he was doing, but also by enabling them to make a contribution. We gave